

The EU confronts its enlargement dilemma

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【メール原文】

Presented by AMD By GABRIEL GAVIN GOOD MORNING. This is Gabriel Gavin, wishing you a happy Friday after a long first week back. As one official said t

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GOOD MORNING. This is Gabriel Gavin, wishing you a happy Friday after a long first week back. As one official said to me this week, summer already feels like it was a long time ago ...

In today's Playbook:

— Ministers are trying to find a way to let new countries into the EU — without them causing headaches in the future.

— Far-right MEPs won't be picked for the European Parliament's new football team.

— Faces in the crowd: Jessika van Leeuwen, Lukas Sieper, Maninder Sidhu, Fernando Sampedro, Claudia Bauer, Thomas Byrne, Nigel Farage, Katharina von Schnurbein, Pinchas Goldschmidt, Cristina Gherasimov, Beyoncé and more.

On the Brussels Playbook Week Ender Podcast: Anne McElvoy talks to Tim Röhn, who's been reporting on the migrant crisis in Ceuta, and to BILD's Josef Forster about the knife-edge election in Saxony-Anhalt.

****A message from AMD: Open standards, interoperability, and supplier diversity will be the cornerstones of Europe's AI future. They drive innovation and choice, strengthen resilience, and provide opportunities to adopt and integrate novel technologies and new capabilities. Read how open technology stack drives choice across hardware, software and deployment models as the EU seeks to build sovereign AI capabilities.****

DRIVING THE DAY

BIGGER, FASTER: EU countries will today tell the Commission to speed up work that would make it easier for new members to join the bloc, warning that the bruising referendum defeat in Iceland should be a wake-up call for enlargement policy.

European affairs ministers and representatives from candidate and potential candidate countries — including Ukraine, Montenegro, Bosnia, North Macedonia, Moldova and Kosovo — will meet today in Dublin for the first major discussion in months on how to break the deadlock and get them into the EU.

Despite broad support for enlargement, EU capitals led by Berlin, Paris and The Hague are worried that admitting them too quickly could cause problems without rules in place to prevent a new member from turning into a troublemaker. It's the Commission's job to draft those rules — and until it finds a solution, the entire process is mired in uncertainty. Ideas such as reverse enlargement have been shot down by capitals.

High stakes: Iceland's decision not to restart membership talks "doesn't help the idea that the EU is a club that lots of people want to be part of," Austria's Europe Minister Claudia Bauer told Playbook. Not admitting those who do want to join, she said, would have "an impact on our credibility" and create a vacuum for "foreign influences, the influences of Russia, of the United States, of China."

The solution, Bauer said, is to design "safeguards that protect the Union without turning accession into a permanent obstacle course."

Tell us what you think: Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos, who will take part in today's meeting, has declared this will be an "autumn of enlargement." She's working up proposals to strip new members of their rights if they break the bloc's rules or disrupt key policies, but is keeping quiet on what these plans might look like. Ireland's Europe Minister Thomas Byrne, who will chair the talks in Dublin, said the plan is expected "towards the end of the month," and today will be a chance to agree what needs to be in it.

Candidate countries are getting restless. "Our government is working full speed," said Moldova's European Integration Minister Cristina Gherasimov, who will attend the talks. "What we need is for the member states to meet us halfway ... the way the EU can help us now is to move [forward] with the political decisions necessary."

Hearts and minds: Bauer also wants the EU to "improve communications on enlargement because there are still skeptical countries and especially skeptical citizens."

Supporters of Germany's far-right Alternative for Germany are particularly skeptical. In a poll conducted by Public First for POLITICO in June, only one-third of German respondents said Ukraine should never become a member of the EU. But among those who said they intended to cast their vote for the AfD in the next national election, that share shot up to 65 percent. It's a strong signal for the EU ahead of this weekend's pivotal election in the eastern state of Saxony-Anhalt, which the AfD looks set to win.

BIG AND BREAKING

ALL EYES ON EASTERN GERMANY: Friedrich Merz and his fragile coalition face political humiliation in Saxony-Anhalt even if the AfD doesn't win enough votes to secure an outright parliamentary majority and govern the state alone, my colleagues Nette Nöstlinger and James Angelos write.

Did the firewall fail? The long-standing policy of mainstream parties refusing to work with the AfD could have helped rather than hindered its route to power, Marc Felix Serrao reports.

Brussels on edge: The prospect of a decisive AfD victory should spur EU capitals to negotiate a compromise on the bloc's long-term budget before a string of elections next year could hand more

power to Euroskeptics, diplomats told me and Zoya Sheftalovich.

SCOOP — O CANADA: Canadian trade chief Maninder Sidhu has been invited to join EU trade talks in Dublin next month as Brussels and Ottawa push for closer ties, POLITICO reports.

AIR DEFENSE CRISIS: Ukraine is facing a major shortfall of interceptor rockets as Russia steps up missile attacks on civilians and infrastructure, Victor Jack and Jacopo Barigazzi write this morning.

ONE-WAY TICKET: Denmark, Germany, the Netherlands, Austria and Greece are expected to agree on the next steps to begin deporting failed migrants to “return hubs” in countries outside the EU when they meet in Copenhagen today , a Danish official told Playbook.

BUDGET BATTLE HEATS UP

SERAFIN — BUDGET CUTS COULD BACKFIRE: EU Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin fears that reductions to the bloc’s next long-term budget would hit the very areas Brussels most wants to strengthen: competitiveness, defense and security. Those top priorities could “become the first victims of cuts,” Serafin told reporters at the informal General Affairs Council yesterday.

Sounding the alarm: Serafin said the Commission’s role in the negotiations now is to point out the consequences of drastic cuts to its nearly €2 trillion proposal for the 2028-2034 budget. Asked what those consequences would be, he told Playbook’s Zoya Sheftalovich: “Less security, less competitiveness.”

Nobody’s baby: If the budget shrinks significantly, Serafin said national governments would likely defend their pet budget topics, such as agriculture and cohesion funding. “I’m not sure who’s going to put competitiveness and security as his or her red line,” he said.

Proving the point: Spain’s Europe Minister Fernando Sampedro said his country opposes any reductions to the Commission’s budget proposal, and wants to protect the ambition for cohesion, agriculture and fisheries. Security and defense are priorities, Sampedro said when pressed by Zoya — but not “at the expense of all other key priorities,” particularly climate change.

Serafin said he is still optimistic about the negotiations, arguing that growing tensions over the size of the Commission’s proposal showed that capitals were finally taking it seriously. “The worst thing for those MFF negotiations is when people take it lightly and don’t engage,” he said. Now, “we are in business.”

Frugals engage: Germany’s Europe Minister Gunther Krichbaum said Berlin’s own budget constraints, weak growth and pressure on its export-heavy industry, including from China and Donald Trump’s tariffs, made the Commission’s proposal a no-go. “We are suffering,” Krichbaum said. “We have to look what is realistic or not of this. The proposal of the European Commission is not realistic.”

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

With Europe paying close attention to the election in Saxony-Anhalt on Sunday, it’s worth asking: What powers do these states have? Quite a lot. The German constitution says the Länder (the states) have the right to legislate unless otherwise stated in the constitution itself. That means the list of regional

powers is long and includes education, health care and policing. That said, the constitution makes it clear that “Federal law shall take precedence over Land law.”

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

****Could the AfD take power in Saxony-Anhalt?** POLITICO’s James Angelos and Nette Nöstlinger will unpack the state election results and what they could mean for the AfD’s ambitions, Germany’s centrist parties and Chancellor Friedrich Merz’s government. Join us for an exclusive online Pro briefing on Tuesday, Sept. 8 at 4 p.m. CEST. Register here .**

PARLIAMENT UNITED?

NO ONE ON THE RIGHT WING: The European Parliament is getting a football team — but far-right lawmakers won’t be allowed to join, according to its founder.

German Renew MEP Lukas Sieper — known for his influencer-style videos on social media — is setting up the team to take on national parliaments from across Europe. There will be a couple of trials to pick the players, but no training sessions, since MEPs’ schedules are simply too full, Sieper told Playbook. Check out its planned logo here .

The first match will be against FC Bundestag, with the “big goal” (pun intended) being to play in the International Parliamentary Football Tournament, which features teams from the German, Finnish, Austrian and Swiss parliaments.

Cordon sanitaire: The team won’t be officially affiliated with the Parliament or receive any funding. MEPs will pay their own way. It will be mixed-gender and players will have to “support the principles of democracy, the rule of law and European integration” to be admitted, according to its draft statutes.

Sieper said it’s “unimaginable” that a member of the far-right Patriots for Europe or Europe of Sovereign Nations groups could meet the criteria, although such decisions will be made on a case-by-case basis by the club board.

HARASSMENT COMPLAINTS: Two MEPs are pressing the European Commission over reports of verbal and physical harassment inside the institution, after a POLITICO investigation revealed almost 1,000 requests had been made to its confidential counsellors since 2024.

ECR MEPs Sander Smit and Jessika van Leeuwen want to know what “concrete measures” the Commission is taking against abuses of power, whether it will publish data on complaints and whether the allegations could damage public trust in the EU.

7 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

MELONI’S MILESTONE: Giorgia Meloni today overtakes Silvio Berlusconi’s record for the longest unbroken stretch as Italian leader since the republic was founded — and she’ll celebrate this evening with a Brothers of Italy rally in Bari.

TROUBLE IN PARADISE: France’s far-right leaders Marine Le Pen and Jordan Bardella are increasingly at odds over key policies like a proposed hijab ban and internal politics, Marion Solletty writes.

ONE TO WATCH TODAY: Bardella will be the star guest at Nigel Farage's Reform UK party conference in Birmingham.

FARAGE'S WISHLIST: Farage will want to thrash out new arrangements with the EU in several key areas if he becomes Britain's next prime minister, including fishing, migration controls and student loans.

BIG GOAL: Ukraine and Poland are contemplating a joint bid to host the men's FIFA World Cup in the 2040s, Martina Sapio scoops .

UNDOING ORBÁN: Hungary's new government wants back into the EU's science and research programs as Péter Magyar tries to heal the rift with Brussels.

NO LOVE LOST: FIFA has accused UEFA of pursuing a "smear campaign" against Gianni Infantino as the spat between the footballing bodies over the failed World Cup privatization plan spills into the U.S. courts, Sky News reports .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Cloudy and breezy with showers. High of 23C.

SPOTTED ... at the launch of the Conference of European Rabbis' seven-point manifesto on countering extremism, held at the Bavarian Representation to the EU: CER President Pinchas Goldschmidt; Health and Animal Welfare Commissioner Olivér Várhelyi; the European Commission's coordinator for combating antisemitism Katharina von Schnurbein; Ludwig Spaenle, Bavarian state government commissioner for Jewish life and against antisemitism; MEP Katarina Barley; and POLITICO's Sebastian Starcevic.

BRUSSELS GOES BROCANTE: Rummaging through other people's stuff at brocante stalls is practically a Belgian way of life. Everyone has that one miraculous find they're still disproportionately proud of. And September brings the tail end of the season before the stalls disappear for winter. This weekend is particularly busy — coinciding, appropriately enough, with the mammoth Braderie de Lille just across the border.

The big one: Ixelles leads the Brussels pack this weekend, with more than 500 sellers taking over the university/cemetery neighborhood until Sunday. There'll also be games, jazz and pop concerts, and other entertainment if rummaging through all those stands somehow isn't enough.

Also supersized: Berchem-Sainte-Agathe's Grand Kermesse promises around 450 sellers, while Watermael-Boitsfort hosts a neighborhood brocante around Avenue des Coccinelles with some 300 stands on Saturday. Schaerbeek's Plasky area and Neder-over-Heembeek each offer another 250 or so.

Brocante with a purpose: Jette's Woeste neighborhood is hosting a smaller, solidarity-minded edition with around 150 sellers, designed to strengthen neighborhood ties and combat social isolation.

Sunday shopping: Forest offers two options — Messor, with around 90 stands, and Rodenbach, with 65 — while Rue Konkel in Woluwe-Saint-Pierre expects around 180. Thieffry in Etterbeek has roughly 200, the Quays district in central Brussels around 150, and Woluwe-Saint-Lambert a more intimate 30.

Missed your bargain? More are coming. Saint-Gilles has a brocante on Sept. 13, while Ganshoren is promising a monster edition beside its château with more than 500 sellers. Woluwe-Saint-Lambert also

has a 500-plus-stand edition later in September, alongside Uccle's Saint-Job brocante.

Happy hunting — and remember: That €3 lamp is only a bargain if you actually have somewhere to put it.

BALKANS AT THE BOURSE: Balkan Trafik! celebrates its 20th anniversary Nov. 19-21 by turning the Brussels Bourse into a festival venue for the first time, with 18 live acts, food, wine, beer and three nights of Balkan revelry. Tickets are already on sale , with limited capacity.

DON'T TAKE THE RED PILLS WITH TRUMP'S FACE ON THEM! The U.S. president's face is everywhere, from illegal drugs to overpriced money, Paul Dallison writes in this week's Declassified column .

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz and his team are bracing for a result in Saxony-Anhalt that could trigger a political earthquake.

Paris: Jordan Bardella will take the stage with Nigel Farage at Reform UK's conference, amid growing talk of a rift at the top of the National Rally.

London: Farage will try to use his big conference speech to reset Reform after a bruising summer.

Washington: Democratic socialists are aiming to replicate the boost Charlie Kirk's Turning Point USA gave Republicans.

Canberra: U.S. Republicans are urging the Trump administration to launch an inquiry into Australia's new media bargaining laws .

AGENDA

— European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen chairs a College seminar in preparation for the State of the European Union. Johan Rockström, director of the Potsdam Institute for Climate Impact Research, and Jim Hagemann Snabe, special envoy for industrial AI, will attend as special guests.

— European Council President António Costa continues his "Tour des Capitales," meeting Cyprus' President Nikos Christodoulides in Nicosia (press conference 9:35 a.m.) and Slovenia's Prime Minister Janez Janša in Ljubljana (press conference 4 p.m.).

— The informal meeting of the General Affairs Council continues in Dublin. Arrivals at 8:30 a.m. ... press conference at 4:30 p.m. Watch live . Enlargement Commissioner Marta Kos will participate in the talks on EU enlargement.

— Budget Commissioner Piotr Serafin meets Irish European Affairs Minister Thomas Byrne in Dublin.

— Consumer Protection Commissioner Michael McGrath meets Ryanair CEO Michael O'Leary.

BIRTHDAYS

Former MEP Henrike Hahn; Aart van Ijzerman of Morris & Chapman; Jan van Zanen, mayor of The Hague; Karen Clements from LOW Europe; former Belgian Deputy Prime Minister Isabelle Durant; The

New York Times' Alex Travelli; pop star Beyoncé turns 45.

Celebrating Saturday: MEP Isabel Benjumea Benjumea; former European Commissioner Máire Geoghegan-Quinn; POLITICO's Sergio Bernabé.

Celebrating Sunday: MEPs Laurence Farreng, Kinga Gál and Marina Kaljurand; former MEPs Nicola Danti and Gianantonio Da Re; Dutch far-right politician Geert Wilders; European Policy Centre's Eric Maurice; POLITICO's Claudia Chiappa. Unification Day in Bulgaria.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Grier, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from AMD: Europe is in a decisive phase in the race to shape its AI future. Building infrastructure that will reinforce long-term autonomy, resilience and competitiveness is an imperative. Choices made now influence who retains leverage, how quickly Europe can respond to change and where the value created by AI ultimately resides. Systems built on open standards and interoperability give institutions, researchers and enterprises the freedom to adapt, integrate new capabilities and avoid dependence on any single technology path. Supplier diversity strengthens that equation by reducing concentration risk and supporting a more resilient innovation ecosystem. A competitive AI ecosystem depends on an open technology stack that enables choice across hardware, software and deployment models.****

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